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Gifted Adolescents' Ability Visibility, Peer Context, and School Settings

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Background

Gifted and high-ability students are often dealing with two needs at once: doing well and fitting in. That basic tension helps explain why peer context, visibility of achievement, and social setting matter so much in the later evidence on hiding ability or changing behavior. (2 sources)

A useful starting point is that the social lives of gifted students are often shaped by a tension between belonging and achievement. In other words, the issue is not just high ability by itself, but the fact that success, visibility, and peer acceptance can pull in different directions during adolescence. Grugan et al. frame this clearly as "personal conflicts between the need to belong and the need to achieve." (Grugan et al., 2021)

More broadly, gifted students can face distinct socio-emotional pressures that make peer context especially important. Reported challenges include feeling different from age peers, asynchronous development between cognitive and social-emotional growth, boredom in unstimulating classrooms, and social rejection linked to stereotypes about intelligence. Some also show withdrawal or disengagement, which can reflect a mismatch with the environment rather than lack of ability. These background conditions help explain why later studies look closely at peer norms, audience effects, gifted versus mixed-ability settings, and identity management in adolescence. (Haikal et al., 2026)

This background does not by itself prove that gifted students actively hide their ability, but it sets up the core question in the empirical literature: when achievement becomes socially risky, do students change how openly they display it across peers, classrooms, and school settings? (Grugan et al., 2021) (Haikal et al., 2026)

Evidence

(Grugan et al., 2021)

Perfectionism in Academically Gifted Students: A Systematic Review

> *"personal conflicts between the need to belong and the need to achieve (Neihart et al., 2018)."*

(Haikal et al., 2026)

Social behavior of children with special needs in school and community interactions: A literature review

> *"Gifted children are often overlooked in discussions of special needs, yet they may experience unique socio-emotional challenges. Giftedness may involve advanced cognitive abilities, heightened sensitivity, and intense emotional experiences. Some gifted children*

struggle with peer relationships due to asynchronous development, where cognitive skills develop faster than social-emotional maturity. They may feel different from peers, experience boredom in school, or face social rejection due to stereotypes about intelligence [1][2][3].

Research suggests that gifted children may display social withdrawal, perfectionism, or difficulty finding peers with similar interests. In some cases, gifted children are misidentified as having behavioral problems due to restlessness or disengagement in unstimulating environments. Therefore, inclusive education should also consider the social needs of gifted learners by providing enrichment opportunities, peer grouping, and supportive counseling when needed [8]."

Direct evidence of audience-dependent behavior change and concealment

Yes—there is direct empirical evidence that some gifted and high-ability students change how openly they show ability depending on who is around. The clearest patterns are hiding giftedness, acting less able, reducing visible achievement, and in some cases underachieving to protect peer acceptance. (6 sources)

The strongest evidence here is not just that gifted students feel social pressure, but that some report changing their behavior in response to different audiences. Reviews of the literature describe repeated findings that gifted youth intentionally act "less gifted" around age-mates, conform to peer behavior, deny or hide giftedness, and sometimes deliberately underachieve when achievement becomes socially costly. One oft-cited example is Gross's report that many highly gifted children "dumbed down" their achievement, thoughts, or behavior for peer acceptance, and that over 70% of early readers changed their reading habits or stopped reading at school—an especially concrete case of behavior changing by setting and audience. (R et al., 2020)

More recent synthesis points the same way. Gifted students are described as using specific social coping strategies such as "hiding giftedness or conforming to peers' behaviors," and these strategies are said to vary by gender, social context, and school environment. That same review also notes that underachievement can function as a coping strategy, which matters because it suggests that lower visible performance can sometimes be socially strategic rather than simply academic failure. (Tourreix et al., 2023)

There is also cross-national interview evidence with children and adolescents that this is an active, audience-aware process. In those interviews, students across several countries showed awareness that their abilities were visible to others, worried about peers' reactions and upward social comparison, and "attempted to hide their abilities or conform to peers' behaviors." This is close to direct evidence of audience-dependent concealment, because the reported behavior is explicitly tied to what classmates might think or feel. (Carter et al., 2025) (Cross et al., 2019)

The same pattern appears in work on gifted underachievement. One qualitative account described a gifted student who accepted being gifted and felt academically capable, but was still hesitant to highlight those abilities because of peer pressure. Related summaries also note that some gifted students may hide giftedness, focus more on social skills than academics, or even "opt for failure" to avoid criticism or ridicule. (Raoof et al., 2024) General discussions of gifted students' social presentation make the mechanism plain: when giftedness becomes known, students may expect different treatment and therefore manage what others know about their abilities so they can keep more normal peer interactions. (Carter et al., 2025)

Taken together, this section of the literature goes beyond indirect claims about peer norms. It provides direct evidence that at least some gifted adolescents and children alter visible achievement-related behavior across audiences and settings—by masking ability, avoiding open displays of pride, changing reading or classroom habits, conforming to peers, or underachieving when social acceptance feels at risk. (R et al., 2020) (Tourreix et al., 2023) (Raoof et al., 2024) (Carter et al., 2025) (Putri et al., 2025)

Evidence

(R et al., 2020)

How Can We Better Understand, Identify, and Support Highly Gifted and Profoundly Gifted Students? A Literature Review of the Psychological Development of Highly-Profoundly Gifted Individuals and Overexcitabilities

"Shaklee [35] noted that highly-profoundly gifted children appeared to be in tune with their differences, and intentionally acted "less gifted" around their age-mates"

".Many of the children in Gross's [3] study deliberately underachieved for peer acceptance. The more highly gifted the child, the greater the social pressure to conform or "dumb-down" his or her achievements, thoughts, or behaviors [12,28,[36][37][38]. For example, Gross [3] reported Anastasia being called melodramatic; the child recounted feeling fake, lonely, and unhappy. While she felt a sense of pride in her own work, her heightened sense of awareness made her acknowledge that she could not express her happiness; Anastasia realized that pride in one's academic success was not socially acceptable. Gross's [36] study found that more than 70% of early readers changed their reading habits or stopped reading altogether at school."

(Tourreix et al., 2023)

Non-Cognitive Specificities of Intellectually Gifted Children and Adolescents: A Systematic Review of the Literature

"There appear to be coping strategies that are specific to giftedness (Swiatek, 1995)(Swiatek, 2001), such as denying giftedness; reducing the impact of giftedness on peer acceptance; hiding giftedness or conforming to peers' behaviors; denying importance of popularity; using humor; helping others; and engaging in social interactions and a high activity level to keep busy and share common interests. These social coping strategies may vary depending on gender, social contexts, and especially the school environment. Culture also seems to have an impact on the preferential use of certain social coping strategies over others in the case of giftedness (see (Cross et al., 2009). For example, hiding conformity is a social coping strategy widely used by gifted students in the United States and some European countries, whereas this is not the case in South Korea where it is socially valued to show the extent of one's abilities"

".Although intellectually gifted children and adolescents do not appear to face more social difficulties than their non-gifted peers on average, they themselves report experiencing pressure from being assigned socially valuable characteristics by others due to their intellectual giftedness. For example, intellectually gifted people are often viewed as "weird" (Coleman et al., 2014)"

".These findings were reported in a situation of classic schooling (e.g., (Peairs et al., 2019), and in a situation of participation in a pull-out enrichment program (e.g., (Cohen et al., 1994). In these same studies, intellectually gifted young people (children in (Cohen et al., 1994)(Košir et al., 2016)(López et al., 2009)adolescents in López and(López et al., 2009)(Peairs et al., 2019) were also categorized by their peers more often as "popular" than as "rejected". (Cohen et al., 1994) also reported good reciprocity in the friendships of intellectually gifted children, and there was a tendency reported by non-gifted peers for gifted children to be less victimized than their peers. (Peairs et al., 2019) found no significant difference between victimization rates of intellectually gifted and non-gifted adolescents, as reported by non-gifted students"

".This approach fails to detect intellectually gifted children and adolescents who are under-achieving, either as a coping strategy (Winner, 2000) or as a consequence of disengagement from school."

(Carter et al., 2025)

School Experiences of Gifted Adolescents and Their Peers

"When their giftedness becomes known to others, gifted students believe that they will be treated differently"

".Gifted students tend to manage the information they reveal about their abilities to maintain a great amount of social latitude"

".Multiple studies have shown that gifted students are aware of the SGP and frequently manage the information others have about them to achieve more typical social interactions within the school environment (Coleman et al., 2014); J. R. (Cross et al., 2019)T. L. Cross et al. 1995;T. L. Cross and Stewart 1995)"

".In line with the SGP, gifted students may engage in efforts to mask their intellectual differences, particularly those that are less overtly visible (T. L. Cross 1997)."

(Cross et al., 2019)

A Cross-Cultural Study of the Social Experience of Giftedness

"The phenomenon of social coping among students with gifts and talents (SWGT) is not well understood. In interviews with elementary-, middle-, and high-school aged SWGT (N = 90; 50% female) from the United States, United Kingdom, South Korea, Ireland, and France, the universality of awareness of visibility of their exceptional abilities, high expectations and pressure to achieve from adults and peers, and peer jealousy and rejection, was confirmed. In all countries, SWGT were concerned about peers' upward social comparison and the effects of their outperformance on peers' feelings. SWGT attempted to hide their abilities or conform to peers' behaviors. Prosocial helping behaviors were found among SWGT in nearly all age groups and a focus on the self was a useful coping strategy to students in all countries except France. Parallels are drawn between these findings and stigma theory."

(Raoof et al., 2024)

Unpacking the underachievement of gifted students: A systematic review of internal and external factors

"The support, pressure, or lack of support from peers also affects the success of gifted students [36]. In a qualitative study, Cavilla examined three underachieved gifted students and observed that one of them was motivated extrinsically due to pressure from their peer group (Cavilla, 2017). Despite accepting the giftedness and having high levels of self-efficacy, this student was hesitant to highlight the abilities to avoid peer pressure. Therefore, the label of giftedness can have different consequences for each person, and some may hide their giftedness to gain peer support and avoid pressure. Positive interactions with peers can help reverse the underachievement of some unsuccessful students (Reis et al., 2000). For some gifted underachievers, feelings of acceptance and love from peers can motivate them. This group may focus on strengthening their social skills more than their academic performance to attract their peers (Cavilla, 2017)"

".Additionally, the culture of judgment towards gifted individuals and social factors may lead them to conceal their giftedness or opt for failure as a means to evade criticism or ridiculed. Even some teachers may hold preconceived notions and stereotypes about the qualities a gifted student should display, leading to further barriers to success (Cavilla, 2017)."

(Putri et al., 2025)

The Role of Peers in the Social-Emotional Development of Gifted Children in Early Childhood Education

"In addition, the pressure to adapt to group habits often encourages gifted children to hide their abilities to be accepted in social settings."

Peer acceptance, rejection, popularity, and anti-intellectual norms

Peer acceptance is a central issue in this literature, not a side effect. Across studies, some gifted adolescents report a real tradeoff between being seen as smart and being accepted, especially in early adolescence and for some girls. (3 sources)

The peer-side of this literature shows that social pressure is often about status and belonging, not just private worry. One study of intellectually gifted students in Australia examined the “forced-choice dilemma” between peer acceptance and academic achievement and found that this conflict was more common for some groups, including males, younger adolescents, and students with peers from different cultural backgrounds; higher levels of giftedness were also linked to more experience of this dilemma. That matters because it shows peer acceptance and achievement can be felt as competing goods, not simply as parallel goals. (Jung et al., 2011)

Other work suggests that when gifted students see high ability as a barrier to fitting in, they also tend to feel less socially accepted. A review summarizing Swiatek’s findings reports that gifted students who saw their ability as an obstacle to belonging, or who denied being gifted, viewed themselves as socially unaccepted by peers, even while still maintaining close friendships. The same review also notes that highly able students can be very aware of what counts as acceptable behavior at school and may be reluctant to talk openly about their strengths, often trying to soften or neutralize signs of excellence before acknowledging them. This is consistent with anti-intellectual peer norms: students may learn that open displays of ability are socially risky even if they are not fully excluded from friendship networks. (Oh et al., 2019)

There is also evidence that popularity and intellectual visibility can diverge over adolescence. A later review reports findings that gifted adolescents, especially girls, can lose earlier popularity by around age 13 as peers increasingly devalue intellectual accomplishment during the secondary school years, and that these students report more difficulty making and keeping friends than they did in elementary school. This helps answer the user’s question about achievement visibility and popularity: the problem is not only rejection in an absolute sense, but a shift in what peers reward socially as students move into adolescence. (Phelps et al., 2021)

Taken together, these studies suggest a fairly consistent picture. Gifted students are not uniformly rejected, and some keep close friends, but peer cultures in adolescence can still punish visible academic strength, make giftedness feel hard to admit openly, and create anti-intellectual norms that push students toward caution in how they present their abilities. (Jung et al., 2011) (Oh et al., 2019) (Phelps et al., 2021)

Evidence

(Jung et al., 2011)

Levels of Intellectual Giftedness, Culture, and the Forced-Choice Dilemma

"This study investigated whether intellectually gifted students in Australia, with different levels of giftedness and cultural orientations, had different experiences of the forced-choice dilemma—choosing between the needs for peer acceptance and academic achievement"

".The study found some support for the hypothesis that level of intellectual giftedness was positively related to the experience of the forced-choice dilemma. It was also shown that those with medium-level vertical allocentric orientations toward the family were likely to be the most vulnerable to the phenomenon. Intellectually gifted male adolescents, intellectually gifted students in early adolescence, and intellectually gifted students with peers of different cultural backgrounds were additional groups identified as being at risk."

(Oh et al., 2019)

Adolescent Perception of Potential High-Performing Classmates: A Cross-National Exploration

"(Swiatek, 2001) study revealed that gifted students who viewed their high ability as an obstacle to fitting in or who denied being gifted in the first place considered themselves socially unaccepted by their peers. They did, however, concede that they maintained close friendships with those peers. Moreover, the work of (Coleman et al., 2014) indicated that highly able students are conscious of what constitutes appropriate behavior at school. The study noted that gifted students are reluctant to talk about their strengths. Before acknowledging their own positive qualities, these students commonly struggled to neutralize excellent aspects about themselves. If it is true that the stereotyping of gifted students discourages them from expressing their own interests to others or engaging in academic activities altogether, then it is reasonable to expect that stereotyping affects the communication skills of these children. It is not necessarily the case that gifted children-and gifted girls in particular-are uninterested in maledominated fields like science, technology, engineering, and mathematics; rather, they are discouraged from vocalizing those interests and strengths."

(Phelps et al., 2021)

Covert Aggression and Gifted Adolescent Girls

"(Lee et al., 2012) researched interpersonal competencies and peer relationships of gifted adolescents and reported intellectually gifted students, particularly girls, lost earlier popular social status by age 13 as peers increasingly devalued their intellectual accomplishments throughout high school. These students reported more difficulty making and maintaining friendships than during elementary school years (p. 92)."

Differences across settings, audiences, and school contexts

The setting matters, but not in one simple direction. Gifted students often seem more socially and intellectually comfortable with similar-ability peers, while mixed-ability settings can protect self-concept in some cases because high ability stands out more positively there. (4 sources)

Across this literature, the main point is not just that peer pressure exists, but that its form changes by classroom and school context. In mixed-ability classrooms, gifted students may have the advantage of being a “big fish in a little pond,” which can support stronger academic self-concept and lower test anxiety than being surrounded only by other gifted students in special classes. A notable review summarizes evidence that gifted students in special gifted classes reported **higher test anxiety** and **lower academic self-concept** than gifted students in regular classes, even though the special setting grouped them with similar peers. (Goetz et al., 2008)

At the same time, ability-grouped settings can make it easier to speak freely and participate without having to downplay one’s ideas. Reviews of homogeneous grouping report that when gifted students are placed together, they can “express their ideas more freely,” experience more mutual respect, and take on leadership roles with greater confidence. That kind of setting may reduce the need to manage how smart one appears in front of less-advanced classmates, even if it does not remove all pressure. (Gorgulu, 2026)

This helps explain why the findings are mixed rather than contradictory. Gifted-only settings may be socially safer for open intellectual expression and equal-level interaction, but they can also raise comparison pressure. One review highlights “latent problems” when gifted children are in highly competitive peer environments and notes that class type has a significant effect on gifted students’ self-concept; interactions with similar-ability peers were described as especially helpful for self-concept development. So the same kind of setting can offer belonging and freer expression while also increasing competition and performance pressure. (Zhang, 2017)

The available evidence also suggests that not every context shift changes observable performance in the same way. One review reports that gifted students performed more similarly across home and school than nongifted students did, and cites work finding that classroom environment did not influence gifted students' academic performance even when matched to their learning styles. That matters for interpretation: social context may change comfort, openness, self-concept, anxiety, or willingness to display ideas more than it changes raw grades or test performance. (Alabbasi et al., 2025)

So for the user's question about gifted classes versus ordinary classrooms, the best answer is that different settings seem to change different things. Mixed-ability settings can buffer self-concept by making high ability more distinctive, while gifted-group settings can reduce the need to hide ideas and can support freer intellectual exchange with similar peers. But gifted-group settings can also intensify comparison and anxiety. Overall, school context does not simply increase or decrease adjustment; it shifts the balance between visibility, competition, belonging, and the social cost of showing ability.

Evidence

(Goetz et al., 2008)

Big fish in big ponds: A multilevel analysis of test anxiety and achievement in special gifted classes

> *"In their study, (Zeidner et al., 1999) 1 compared the level of test anxiety and academic self-concept reported by gifted students in regular classes with the respective levels reported by their gifted counterparts in special gifted classes"*
>
> *".As expected, gifted students in special gifted classes (i.e., big fish in big ponds) reported higher levels of test anxiety and lower levels of academic self-concept than gifted students in regular classes (i.e., big fish in little ponds)."*

(Gorgulu, 2026)

Leadership experiences of gifted students: A meta-synthesis of qualitative studies

> *"in Begnaud's (1999) study, it was stated that in a separate classroom environment where gifted students were homogeneously grouped, students could express their ideas more freely and a learning climate based on mutual respect could be established"*
>
> *". The data from Behrend (2013) and Begnaud (1999) suggest that homogeneous grouping-placing gifted students together in dedicated classes or pullout programs-may create more conducive conditions for leadership emergence. Students reported that learning alongside intellectual peers enabled them to express ideas more freely, take on leadership roles with greater confidence, and engage in more stimulating academic discourse."*

(Zhang, 2017)

Gifted education in China

> *"This study showed the latent problems of gifted children when they are in a class environment with highly competitive peers and feel pressure to succeed in academic performance"*
>
> *".Su, Tan, and Fang (2010) showed that IQ has a positive relation with the academic self-concept, and that class type (whether the class consists only of supernormal students or mostly normal students) had a significant effect on the self-concept of gifted high school students. Specifically, equal level social interactions (with students of a similar level intelligence and academic performance) were most beneficial for the development of gifted students' self-concept."*

(Alabbasi et al., 2025)

The Impact of Setting, Time of Day, and Giftedness on Divergent Thinking Test Scores

> *"They found that nongifted students performed better when they were at home than when they were at school. Gifted students, on the other hand, performed more equivalently at home and at school. In a different study, (Rayneri et al., 2006) investigated the relationship between classroom environment, learning styles, and academic achievement. They found that the classroom environment did not influence gifted students' academic performance even when it was compatible with their learning styles."*

Gender, adolescence, friendship groups, and transitions/identity-related moderators

These patterns are not the same for all gifted students. Gender, age, comfort with a gifted identity, and the kind of friendship group a student has can all change how risky it feels to be visibly high-ability. (5 sources)

Moderators in this literature mostly work by changing how safe gifted students feel in their social world. One clear factor is friendship security. In academically selective high schools, secure peer groups were linked to better social and emotional outcomes, while strong pressure to academically outperform peers could make it harder to form close ties. The same study also found that being female and being in seventh grade predicted higher friendship quality, which suggests that social protection can vary both by gender and by developmental stage even within high-achieving settings (Banat et al., 2020). This matters for the main question because friendship groups can either buffer the social cost of visible achievement or make status competition sharper.

Gender patterns are also mixed, but they matter. In one cross-national study, gifted students rated their interpersonal ability and peer relationships as comparable to or better than those of nongifted students overall, and girls in both the Korean and American samples rated these areas more positively than boys did (Yong et al., 2021). But that does not mean girls always have an easier time displaying high ability openly. A more recent interpretive account links some girls' lower visibility to the classic "Underground" pattern, where gifted students reduce the visibility of talent for relational reasons, and it argues that gifted girls may face pressures toward underrecognition, invisibility, or self-presentation styles that make ability less obvious in class (Torello et al., 2026) (Perales et al., 2019). So the gender finding is not simply that girls do worse socially; rather, girls may sometimes maintain relationships while also learning to present ability in quieter, less visible ways.

Adolescence itself also seems to be a key moderator, especially because identity becomes more socially loaded in these years. One study notes that gifted adolescents differ greatly in how comfortable they feel with the gifted label (Snyder et al., 2013). That variation in label comfort helps explain why some students openly claim giftedness while others distance themselves from it, especially after school transitions or in new peer groups where identity has to be renegotiated. In practical terms, the social meaning of being "the smart one" may become more unstable from ages 11 to 18, and students' behavior can shift with that instability.

Taken together, the moderator evidence suggests that audience-dependent hiding or softening of ability is most likely when three things come together: weak or competitive peer ties, low comfort with a gifted identity, and social contexts where gendered expectations shape how acceptable visible intelligence seems. By contrast, secure friendships and positive peer relations can reduce the need to manage giftedness so carefully, even if they do not remove it completely (Banat et al., 2020) (Yong et al., 2021) (Snyder et al., 2013).

Evidence

(Banat et al., 2020)

The effectiveness of a group counseling program in enhancing the ability to form friendship among academically talented students

> *"secure peer groups have a positive influence on the social and emotional outcomes of students who attend academically selective high schools"*
>
> *". if one is driven academically to outperform peers, this may negatively affect their ability to form close ties with peers"*
>
> *". Being a female, seventh grader, or adolescent not identified as gifted, significantly predicted higher friendship quality."*

(Yong et al., 2021)

Social-Emotional Development of Children in Asia: A Systematic Review

> *"Gifted students positively perceived their interpersonal ability and peer relationships at a level comparable to or higher than non-gifted students. Female students in both the Korean and American samples were reportedly more positive in rating their profiles of interpersonal ability and peer relationships compared to male students."*

(Torello et al., 2026)

Gendered Recognition of Giftedness in Italian Primary Schools: A Mixed-Methods Study of Teachers' Perceptions

> *"From a theoretical perspective, these findings align with the "Underground" profile described by (Betts et al., 1988), which refers to*

gifted pupils who reduce the visibility of their talent for relational and adaptive reasons. Although this is a descriptive model rather than a causal test, it provides a useful frame for interpreting why some girls perceived as gifted may not be recognised through highly visible cues. (Reis, 1987) similarly highlighted that gifted girls may face specific pressures linked to social and school expectations, with a risk of underachievement or invisibility. While the present study does not directly measure underachievement, it points to a plausible educational antecedent: a lower likelihood of being recognised as gifted within teachers' discourse. Complementary evidence also suggests that gender differences in psycho-educational variables, such as self-esteem, may indirectly contribute to different self-presentation styles, with implications for the visibility of potential in the classroom (Perales et al., 2019). In this light, the literature on gifted females has also described internal barriers and personal decisions that may reduce the visibility of girls' talent, particularly in contexts that reinforce compliance and the ethic of caring (Reis, n.d.)."

(Perales et al., 2019)

Alta capacidad y género: la autoestima como factor influyente en las diferencias entre sexoss entre sexos

"Los resultados obtenidos en el diagnóstico de altas capacidades son significativamente menores en niñas que en niños; sin embargo, no se encuentran estudios concluyentes que confirmen diferencias en la inteligencia en función del sexo. La literatura publicada sitúa los estereotipos de género y la autoestima como variables fundamentales en la brecha existente. Razonadamente, hemos realizado una investigación cuantitativa de la autoestima en 118 sujetos de 4º, 5º y 6º de Educación Primaria, comparando después los resultados en función de distintas variables moduladoras. Se ha utilizado la Escala de Autoestima de Rosenberg. Los resultados confirman que sí existen diferencias en la autoestima en función del sexo, siendo las niñas las que presentan niveles más bajos. El rendimiento académico es otra variable que correlaciona positivamente con la autoestima. No se han hallado resultados significativos que relacionen el constructo evaluado con la edad, el curso, las altas capacidades diagnosticadas o el tipo de centro de los sujetos. Las conclusiones se centran en la demanda de nuevas investigaciones que analicen la posible vinculación de la discriminación de la mujer con su no adecuada autoestima, centrándonos en las mujeres con altas capacidades."

(Snyder et al., 2013)

Identification as Gifted and Implicit Beliefs About Intelligence: An Examination of Potential Moderators

"gifted adolescents vary greatly in self-reported comfort with the gifted label (Robinson, 1990)."